



Phase 1 — Ola Product Discovery

Product Selected: OLA

Why I chose Ola..?

I chose Ola because I use it frequently and have personally experienced a few situations where I felt there could be some difficulties for users that are worth exploring. I also felt that Ola would be a useful product to explore because I can interact with other users and understand whether the problems I observed are common or specific to my own experience.

What does it do?

Ola is a digital ride-hailing platform that acts as a bridge between drivers and passengers. It connects passengers with drivers to help them travel from Point A to Point B, while providing information such as the estimated fare and travel time.

Where is it available?

Ola is available across India, with ride services offered in more than 100 cities. Availability of specific ride types may vary by city.

01 — Observe Product & Business

Product Observation

<u>What I tried</u>	<u>What worked well</u>	<u>Where I had to work</u>
Opening and using the app	The app provides a digital way to arrange a ride without having to find a vehicle physically.	I need to use the app and provide the required trip information.
Entering pickup location	The app uses location information to help identify the pickup point.	I need to check whether the pickup location shown is actually where I can be picked up.
Entering destination	The destination can be entered digitally before booking.	I need to make sure the destination entered is correct.
Choosing a ride	Different ride options can be compared before booking.	I need to compare options based on factors such as fare and expected travel time.
Checking fare & ETA	The app provides an estimated fare and travel time before booking.	I need to compare the estimate with my expected travel time and cost.
Booking the ride	The platform connects the passenger with a driver.	I have to wait for a driver to be assigned/accept the ride.
Waiting for the driver	The app provides information about the driver's arrival.	I have to wait and keep track of the driver's arrival.
Tracking the driver	I can see information about the driver's location and ride status.	I may need to keep checking the driver's location while waiting.
During the ride	The journey can be followed through the app.	I have to rely on the route being followed and monitor the journey when necessary.
Unexpected route change	The driver can adapt the journey to road/traffic conditions.	If the route changes, I may need to understand why it changed and whether it affects my expected time or fare.
Completing the ride	The journey is completed digitally and the trip details are recorded.	I may need to check the final fare when it differs from my initial expectation.
Payment	Payment can be completed using available payment	I may need to verify or complete the payment depending on the payment

<u>What I tried</u>	<u>What worked well</u>	<u>Where I had to work</u>
	options.	method.
Rating / feedback	I can provide feedback after the ride.	I need to decide whether I want to provide feedback about the experience.
Return journey / booking another ride	I can book another ride after completing the first journey.	In some situations, a passenger may have to repeat the booking process and communicate the pickup location again.

Key Observations

Observation 1 — Return Journey / Booking Dependency

I observed a situation involving a person who was not comfortable using apps independently. A family member who was familiar with the app booked an auto for them.

After completing their work at the destination, the person needed to return. Since they were not comfortable using the app, they depended on the same family member to book the return ride.

During the return booking, identifying and communicating the exact pickup location created additional effort. The passenger had to communicate the location to the family member, who then had to use that information to make the booking.

Observation: A passenger who is not comfortable using the app may face additional effort and dependency when arranging a return journey.

Initial solution thought: A “Return” or “Book Again” option that could reuse relevant trip details.

PM note: The solution is only an initial idea. We need to understand whether this situation occurs commonly and what exactly causes the difficulty.

Observation 2 — Unexpected Route Changes

I observed a situation where the passenger had an expected route, travel time and fare at the time of booking. During the journey, the driver followed a different/longer route.

In one situation, the longer journey contributed to the passenger reaching the destination later than expected, which resulted in the person missing a bus.

This made me think about the gap between the passenger's expectation at booking and the actual journey experience.

Observation: A route change can potentially make the actual journey different from what the passenger expected in terms of route and travel time, and may also affect fare expectations.

Safety consideration: An unexpected route change may also make a passenger uncomfortable, particularly when travelling alone or in an unfamiliar area.

Initial solution thought: If a significant route change is required, the passenger could be informed and given visibility into the change.

PM note: I should not assume that the driver intentionally chooses a longer route to increase the fare. There could be other reasons such as traffic, road closures, navigation issues or passenger preferences. This needs to be investigated.

Business Understanding

How does Ola make money?

Ola's ride-hailing business connects passengers with driver-partners through its platform. Its business model has evolved over time, including a move toward a zero-commission model for drivers announced in 2025.

Who pays and for what?

The passenger pays for the transportation service. Ola provides the technology/platform that connects passengers and drivers and facilitates the ride-booking experience.

What seems to be Ola's recent focus?

One notable recent focus has been changing the economics of the driver side of the marketplace. Ola announced a zero-commission model in 2025, allowing driver-partners to retain their full fare earnings while using subscription-based plans.

02 — Competitor Analysis

Competitors

Competitor	Type	Why users might choose it instead
Uber	Direct	Similar ride-hailing service and an alternative when users compare availability, price and experience.
Rapido	Direct	Provides bike, auto and cab options and can be attractive for shorter trips.
Bharat Taxi	Direct / emerging	Uses a cooperative model and a zero-commission approach for drivers.
Public transport / local autos	Indirect	Can be chosen when cost, availability or convenience is better suited to the trip.

Where might users go instead?

Users may choose another option when:

- another app has better availability;
- another service appears cheaper;
- a bike or auto is more convenient for a short journey;
- they have had a better experience with another platform;
- local transport is cheaper or easier.

Substitution Moment

Situation: A passenger needs to travel a short distance during a busy period.

Instead of booking an Ola cab, the passenger may choose a bike or auto option from another platform if it is available sooner or appears cheaper.

What this tells us: The competition is not only between apps. Users are choosing among different ways to accomplish the job of **getting from A to B conveniently, predictably and at an acceptable cost.**

Category Change

The ride-hailing category is becoming more competitive, with platforms experimenting with different approaches to driver economics, pricing and marketplace models.

03 — Map User Segments

Main Use Cases

Use case	What the person is trying to accomplish
Daily commute	Travel regularly between home and work/college.
Occasional local travel	Reach a destination without using their own vehicle.
Time-sensitive travel	Reach a destination within a specific time.
Airport / railway travel	Reach a transport hub while managing time and luggage.
Return journey	Travel back after completing an activity at the destination.
Booking for someone else	Arrange a ride for a family member or another person.
Short-distance travel	Complete a short trip conveniently.

Primary User Groups

Passengers

Frequent passengers

People who use ride-hailing regularly and are comfortable with app-based booking.

Occasional passengers

People who use the service when needed and may not be highly familiar with the app.

Passengers travelling alone

People who may place greater importance on predictability and confidence during the journey.

Passengers who depend on others for booking

People who may need family members or others to arrange their rides.

Drivers

Frequent / full-time drivers

Drivers who depend heavily on ride-hailing for income.

Part-time drivers

Drivers who use the platform alongside other work.

Core Needs

Segment	What are they trying to accomplish?	Core need
Frequent passengers	Travel regularly	Convenience and reliability
Occasional passengers	Arrange a ride when needed	Simple booking
Solo passengers	Complete their journey confidently	Predictability and confidence
Passengers dependent on others	Get a ride without managing the app themselves	Easy coordination
Drivers	Get ride opportunities	Demand and predictable earnings

04 — Find Problems & Set Goal

Potential Problems / Hypotheses

These are **potential problems based on current observations**, not validated findings.

S.no	Potential problem	Segment
1	"When I need to return from a place, I may have to repeat the booking process even though I just	Passengers

S.no	Potential problem	Segment
	travelled from there."	
2	"If I am not comfortable using the app, I may have to depend on someone else to book my return ride."	Passengers dependent on others
3	"Finding or communicating the exact pickup location can be difficult when someone else is booking the ride for me."	Passengers dependent on others
4	"If the route changes during my ride, I may not understand why it changed."	Passengers
5	"If the route is longer than expected, my journey may take more time than I planned."	Time-sensitive passengers
6	"If the route changes, I may be uncertain about how it will affect my final fare."	Passengers
7	"If my journey takes longer than expected, I may miss an important connection or appointment."	Time-sensitive passengers
8	"An unexpected route change may make me uncomfortable when I am travelling alone."	Solo passengers

Problem Clusters

Cluster 1 — Return Journey & Booking Dependency

Problems **1–3** are connected.

Underlying theme:

Passengers who are not comfortable using the app may face additional effort or dependency when arranging a return journey.

Cluster 2 — Journey Predictability

Problems **4–8** are connected.

Underlying theme:

Passengers may experience a gap between what they expect when booking and what happens during the actual journey.

Areas Selected for Further Exploration

1. Return Journey / Booking Dependency

This comes directly from an experience I observed involving a passenger who depended on another person to arrange both the initial and return journeys.

2. Journey Predictability

This comes from my observation of a journey where a route change contributed to a longer journey and caused a passenger to miss a bus.

These two areas are distinct enough to investigate separately.

Goal

Understand the key challenges passengers face during different stages of their ride journey.

05 — Pick Problems to Probe

Problem 1 — Return Journey / Booking Dependency

Passengers who are not comfortable using the app independently may struggle to arrange their return journey because they may need another person to repeat the booking process and communicate the pickup location.

Why I want to investigate it

I observed this situation personally and want to understand whether it is a recurring problem for other passengers who depend on family members or others for ride booking.

What I want to learn

- How often do people book rides for someone else?
- Do passengers commonly need help with return bookings?

- What exactly makes the return booking difficult?
 - Is the main difficulty the pickup location, app usage, or something else?
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Problem 2 — Unexpected Route Changes / Journey Predictability

Passengers may struggle with unexpected route changes because they may not understand why the route changed or how the change could affect their travel time and fare.

Why I want to investigate it

I observed a situation where a route change contributed to a longer journey and resulted in a passenger missing a bus. I want to understand whether this is a recurring experience and how passengers perceive route changes.

What I want to learn

- How often do passengers notice significant route changes?
- How do they react when the route changes?
- Do they understand why the route changed?
- Does the change affect their expectation of travel time or fare?
- Does an unexpected route change affect their confidence or feeling of safety?